to crystallise into decisive victories. In 2020, the RJD had emerged as the single largest party, securing 75 seats and a 23.1 per cent vote share, thanks largely to a job-centric campaign that delivered nearly 39 per cent of the vote in the 144 constituencies the party had contested. Yet, it was not enough in the absence of fresh constituencies to compensate for incremental losses among the EBCs, Dalits and women, and the RJD-led Grand Alliance fell short of forming the government by a mere 12 seats. In the 2024 Lok Sabha election, the RJD amassed 9.6 million votes—the highest for any party in Bihar—yet they translated into just four parliamentary seats. The NDA, on the other hand, maintained a lead in 176 of the state's 243 assembly segments.

With the assembly polls now due in six months, Tejashwi is determined not merely to reprise the campaign themes of 2020, but also to extend his party's outreach well beyond the customary "M-Y" coalition of Muslims (17 per cent of the population) and Yadavs. Together, the M-Y are a formidable bloc, but still insufficient if the NDA succeeds in peeling away chunks of the remaining voters. Hence the new, amplified refrain: shared welfare, enhanced security and unflinching accountability.

SOMETHING FOR EVERYBODY

For the EBCs, Tejashwi is holding out the lure of targeted employment schemes, local infrastructure projects and community-led policing initiatives to safeguard women. To Dalits, he is offering land title regularisation and scholarships; to urban entrepreneurs, simplified licensing and relief from punitive "GST raids". Women's collectives are being promised not just security and empowerment but also a monthly social security stipend of Rs 2,500. Of course, Tejashwi's polyphonic appeal could well boomerang. By courting these new constituents, he risks alienating his loyal supporters. His core M-Y vote bank could resent overtures to erstwhile rivals; the NDA is already portraying him as a political opportunist. And while onerous compliances and sporadic enforcement crackdowns may have bred discontent among Bihar's traders, they may hold back, driven by scepticism after years of U-turns by regional parties.

RJD'S SUPER-SIZED PLATTER

FOR THE BUSINESS/ ELITE CASTES

- **PROMISES:** Investment, security, end to tax harassment
- **PITCH:** "Walk one step with me, I'll walk four with you"
- **SIGNAL:** RJD is not anti-business

FOR THE EBCs

- **PROMISES:** Jobs, caste-based quotas, political representation
- **PITCH:** "No EBC has been empowered under Nitish"
- **SIGNAL:** Reclaiming the mandate of social justice

FOR WOMEN

- Every woman will get Rs 2,500 monthly stipend

Yet, the momentum is clearly shifting. Bihar's caste survey has reignited the public debate on representation. Promises to field more backward class candidates than ever in 2025 have sparked enthusiasm in communities long accustomed to tokenism. There is also the generational shift, something the 35-year-old Tejashwi brings up regularly against the 73-year-old Nitish. In speech after speech, he refers to the incumbent as "tired...retired, even".

Tejashwi's youthful brio also comes with a strategic nod to dynasty and his father Lalu Prasad's contributions. The RJD patriarch remains the patron saint of Bihar's social justice politics, but his rule is also identified as a '*jangal raj*' that deprived the state of growth opportunities. Aware of the contradiction, Tejashwi takes pains to paint Lalu's legacy as one of empowerment, not of chaos, and himself as someone who can carry it forward while marrying it with 21st century imperatives.

WILL IT WORK?

In a state where electoral fortunes have swung on margins as slim as a few thousand votes, even modest gains among EBCs, traders or women could prove decisive. But Tejashwi's strategy demands near-flawless execution. For that, he'll first have to get the allies in line. Tejashwi's big challenge will be to persuade the Congress to cap its ticket count at around 50 seats. In 2020, the party fought in 70 seats but managed only 19 wins (even the CPI-ML had a better strike rate—12 wins in 19 seats contested). The RJD chief also has to accommodate two new parties: Mukesh Sahani's Vikassheel Insaan Party (VIP), which won four of the 13 seats it contested as an NDA ally in 2020, and Pashupati Paras's faction of the Lok Janshakti Party (LJP).

Meanwhile, there are fresh ripples from another quarter—Prashant Kishor's newly formed Jan Suraj party. Riding a wave of disaffection with traditional party hierarchies, Kishor's party promises clean governance, community-driven development and a break from entrenched dynastic politics. Partymen claim it will get 5-7 per cent of the Muslim vote in key districts, depriving the RJD—which considers Muslim voters as part of its natural constituency—of the very margins it needs to convert popular support into legislative strength. This election, Tejashwi will have his hands full, as he must reckon with the old NDA and the new rival. ■